

Older Adults



Ginseng
(*Panax ginseng*)

Traditionally, as we age, the “fire” or *qi* within us glows less brightly and our vitality slowly weakens. Many herbal medicines are ideally suited to treating the health problems that begin when people reach their late fifties, such as circulatory problems, weak digestion, and poor memory. The herbs recommended here can help to maintain good health, preventing or reducing the severity of symptoms that are often accepted as an inevitable consequence of aging. Self-treatment for other problems often experienced later in life, such as arthritis, is suggested in earlier sections.

Important Note

- If taking conventional medication, tell your doctor if you intend to take an herbal remedy. This is especially important for the elderly.
- All remedies on this page need to be taken continuously for up to 3 months.
- If you are over 70 years of age, take $\frac{3}{4}$ of the stated dose for remedies given on other pages in this book.

Maintaining Vitality

Many herbs help to maintain vitality.

Thyme is a much underrated herb. Recent research has discovered that it has antiaging and tonic properties that maintain vitality and reduce the chance of catching colds, flu, and other respiratory infections.

Ashwagandha is a tonic, calming herb that may slow the aging process. It is particularly suited to aid recovery from long-term illness.

Ginseng is well known as a remedy that supports vitality and resistance to stress and infection in older people.

Rhodiola has similar tonic, restorative properties to ashwagandha and ginseng, but enhances mental performance and has a mild antidepressant activity.

General Remedy

Herb Thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143)

Remedy Make a standard infusion. Take 1¼–1½ cups (300–450 ml) a day.

Stress or Convalescence

Herb Ashwagandha (*Withania somnifera*, p. 152)

Remedy Take 1 g of the root 2–3 times a day, either by chewing it or chopping it and mixing with a little water.

Herb Ginseng (*Panax ginseng*, p. 118)

Remedy Take 1 g 1–2 times a day for up to 3 months. Chew the fresh or dried root, cook it in a soup, or take in tablet form.

Caution Do not take caffeine while taking ginseng.

Option If ginseng is too stimulating, take 3 g of codonopsis (*Codonopsis pilosula*, p. 83) a day in the same way as ginseng. This has a milder, but nonetheless tonic and strengthening, effect.

Nervous Exhaustion & Stress

Herb Oats (*Avena sativa*, p. 175)

Remedy Eat 25 g of oats each day (for example, as a hot cereal). Alternatively, take ½ tsp of the tincture twice a day.

Herb Rhodiola (*Rhodiola rosea*, p. 127)

Remedy Take ½ tsp (2.5 ml) of tincture 2–3 times a day or as recommended by supplier.

General Conditions

Conditions that arise through aging need patient, long-term treatment.

Ginkgo is the oldest tree on the planet. Its leaves maintain good circulation to the head and brain, improving memory, concentration, and energy levels. Evidence suggests it may reduce the risk of a stroke.

Gotu kola has significant anti-inflammatory activity, for example in arthritis, but is also a tonic that helps to protect the nervous system and to maintain memory and cognition.

Garlic has great value as a long-term dietary supplement, helping to maintain healthy circulation, balance blood-sugar levels, reduce high blood pressure and fat levels in the blood, and improve resistance to infection, especially bronchitis.

Rehmannia, a Chinese tonic herb with strengthening and mildly stimulant properties, appears to lower blood pressure and blood fat levels. It is suitable for people who have a weak liver and metabolism.

Gentian, a bitter herb, helps the absorption of food by maintaining digestive secretions, which diminish with age.

Failing Memory & Concentration

Herb Ginkgo (*Ginkgo biloba*, p. 100)

Remedy Take ginkgo tablets. These need to be taken regularly for at least 3 months.

Herb Gotu kola (*Centella asiatica*, p. 76)

Remedy Take tablets or ½ tsp tincture twice a day.

Poor Circulation & High Blood Pressure

Herb Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59)

Remedy Take 1–2 raw cloves a day with food, or take garlic tablets or capsules on a regular basis.

Herb Buckwheat (*Fagopyrum esculentum*, p. 210)

Remedy Make a standard infusion and drink up to 1¼ cup (300 ml) a day.

Chronic Infections

Herbs Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59), echinacea (*Echinacea* spp., p. 92)

Remedy Take 1–2 raw cloves of garlic each day with food, or take either herb in tablet or capsule form on a regular basis.

Weakened Liver & Metabolism

Herb Rehmannia (*Rehmannia glutinosa*, p. 125)

Remedy Chew 5 g of root 1–3 times a day, or make a decoction with 5 g of root to 1 cup (250 ml) of water and take 1–3 times a day.

Weakened Digestion

Herb Gentian (*Gentiana lutea*, p. 99)

Remedy Take 5–10 drops of tincture with water about 30 minutes before eating, 3 times a day.

Caution Do not take gentian if you suffer from acid indigestion or a peptic ulcer.

Arthritic Pain & Rheumatism

See *Joint Pain & Stiffness, Including Arthritis & Gout*, p. 313.

Note Take one of the remedies for a maximum of 2–3 weeks. If there is no improvement, consult an herbal practitioner.